

Ransom-weary attacks

ONE OF THE BIGGEST REMINDERS ON WHY CYBERSECURITY IS SO VERY IMPORTANT IN OUR LIVES WAS PRESENTED BY A SCENARIO NOT MANY PEOPLE WOULD GUESS TO BE A CYBERATTACKER'S TARGET. You expect banks to get hit, high-profile personalities' phones to be hacked into, but taking down a hospital's digital systems? Where's the fun in that? As unlikely as it seems, this really happened.

On a random, unsuspecting Thursday in late November 2022, the All India Institute of Medical Sciences in the national capital, also known as AIIMS New Delhi, reported a failure in accessing its central server. According to multiple reports, the prestigious healthcare centre's hospital management system in part or totality was offline, effectively rendering it useless. A suspected cyberattack, specifically a ransomware attack, was being blamed as the unfortunate cause of this service disruption.

Imagine a modern, multi-speciality hospital where everything from creating your case file to getting you discharged is done digitally through a computer terminal at the reception section of the hospital's OPD (outpatient department). After consulting with a physician, if you're recommended to do additional tests – like X-Ray or advanced diagnostics, all those departments keep adding to your case file digitally at this hospital. All of this is tracked internally, from department to department, nursing staff to doctors, through the hospital management system. Think of it like an operating system that's at the heart of the whole operation (no pun intended), guiding the flow of patients from entry to exit in a smooth and timely manner. This is essentially what the cyberattack on AIIMS New Delhi impacted; and by effectively taking out the digital system that managed patients inside the hospital, the medical authorities had to revert to offline management of patients, delaying everything related to their healthcare by a huge stretch. It could very well have jeopardised some – if not all – of the AIIMS' patients' lives, but it seems the worst may have been averted at this point.

While everyone from the Delhi Police's Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations to National Investigation Agency, teams from NIC to CERT-In probed to identify the source of the cyber breach and restoration of AIIMS' hospital network, which remained offline for over two

weeks (at the time of writing this column) – a leading cyber security software company's India head revealed to me that the delay in restoring the hospital's network wasn't exactly because of the alleged ransomware attack. It's just that all the investigating agencies wanted to be confident that the attackers were no longer in any of the infected systems, that they were effectively cut off after the cyber forensic restoration. This entire episode ensured one of the most advanced hospitals in India remained below-par in its ability to treat patients, especially new patients, severely impacting the healthcare machinery that thousands if not lakhs of patients depend on.

The AIIMS ransomware attack wasn't an isolated incident, as just a month before that in October 2022 news broke of Tata Power, an Indian energy company which serves more than 12 million customers, confirming that it had been hit by a cyberattack that impacted some of its IT system. The Hive ransomware group took responsibility for the Tata Power cyberattack, and they immediately started leaking the data they stole from Tata Power's systems onto the dark web – the stolen data included employee information, like Aadhaar numbers, PAN details, home addresses and phone numbers.

What if the cyber attackers had brought down Tata Power's electricity distribution network in some capacity, very much like the crippling attack on AIIMS hospital? Where hundreds of thousands of people faced with the reality of living with no electricity for a number of days? The loss to the country's economic engine it would've caused? Unimaginable.

Unfortunately, these two incidents are just the tip of the nefarious cyber threat iceberg. If you search the internet, you'll come across a lot of cyber threat reports, and almost all of them feature India at the very top of the most targeted nations by cybercriminals in the world. When you look at the range of phishing scams from shady apps to brute-force attacks that are consumer-focused, it's easy to feel despondent and think you can't do much to keep yourself safe online. Not only is it the wrong attitude to defend yourself from cyberattacks, you should follow all the safety guidelines and defend your online footprint as best you can. Stay focused, stay vigilant! 



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